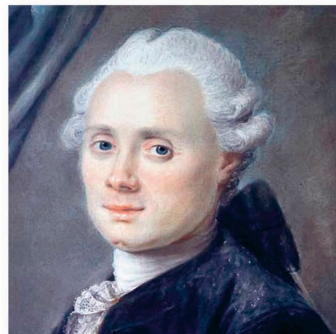


Fuzzy objects

In the night sky, stars look like twinkling points of light and planets look like small bright disks. However, you can also see lots of fuzzy dots and patches of misty light in the sky. These may be galaxies that look misty because they are so far away, or they could be clusters of stars or nebulae that are much closer.



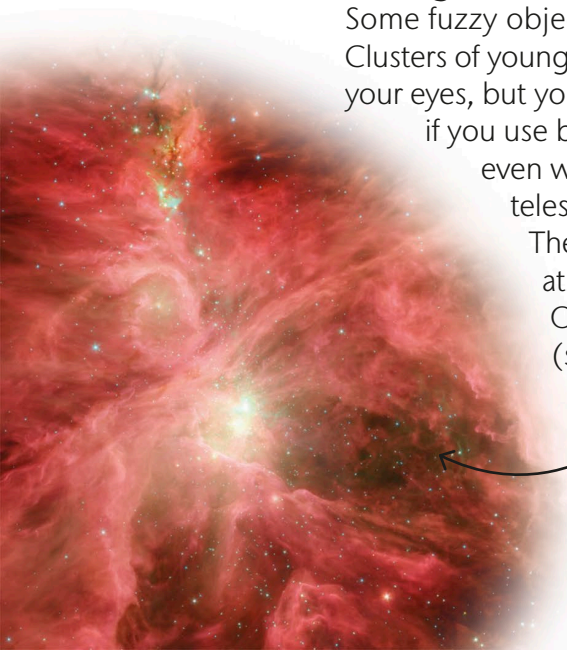
Lookalikes

Over 200 years ago, French astronomer Charles Messier started listing fuzzy objects in the sky. Some have names that describe the way they look.

Taking a closer look

Some fuzzy objects we see are not really fuzzy. Clusters of young stars like the Pleiades look fuzzy to your eyes, but you can see they are a group of stars if you use binoculars. Some objects stay fuzzy even when viewed through very powerful telescopes. These objects are nebulae.

The word nebula means “misty.” Look at the sword in the constellation of Orion and you’ll see a misty patch (see p.18).



The Orion Nebula is a huge cloud of gas and dust where stars are born. It is lit up by the young stars in it.